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Source: *Comparative Education Review*, Vol. 56, No. 1 (February 2012), pp. 18-47
Published by: The University of Chicago Press on behalf of the Comparative and International Education Society
Stable URL: http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1086/661252
Accessed: 25-04-2016 04:52 UTC

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Whose Education Policies in Aid-Receiving Countries? A Critical Discourse Analysis of Quality and Normative Transfer through Cambodia and Laos

ALEXANDRA MCCORMICK

Critical discourse analysis of policy contexts and documents has been employed in this research to analyze the role of language in promoting normative positions affecting the quality of education in Cambodia and Laos. The article examines the ways institutional normative influences at multiple levels within the Education for All (EFA) program have influenced education policies in aid-receiving countries. This includes "harmonization" processes through which policies are formed and promulgated, and some implications for national ownership and the quality of education in relation to these processes.

National and global education monitoring reports foreground striking statistical improvements in formal universal primary education (UPE; MoEYS 2007). However, practitioners and researchers alike criticize the substantive value and structural bias inherent in these figures (Samoff 2007; Alexander 2008). Donor and government emphasis on often inaccurate or unrepresentative schooling access statistics has undermined the quality of education in countries identified as "developing" (Bredenburg 2000; Abadzi 2004). In terms of pedagogy and theory, opening the "black box of educational processes" can sit uneasily with project or sector "efficiency" in pursuit of growth and related political expediency (Tikly 2004, 194; Abadzi 2004).

An analysis of the interplay between educational development discourses at multiple levels can improve our understanding of why quality of education appears as another box in templates required for securing donor funds. By comparing national Education for All (EFA) policy processes through critical discourse analysis (CDA), this research examines the socially constructed contexts for educational development strategies. It interprets educational development documents as powerful components of those contexts (Blommaert 2010). Framing CDA in a multidisciplinary and critical development

I am grateful to the Australian Research Council and the Australian Agency for International Development for funding the research on which this article is based.

Received June 19, 2009; revised March 24, 2010, November 10, 2010, and March 29, 2011; accepted June 5, 2011; electronically published November 8, 2011

Comparative Education Review, vol. 56, no. 1.
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0010-4086/2012/5601-0006$10.00

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theoretical perspective reveals processes associated with competing educational development agendas. The broader theme I address in this article is the normative institutional influences of the global EFA initiative on national educational development policies. More specifically, I hope to contribute insights into education policy making in Cambodia and Laos.

Through a CDA of process-based and written discursive elements, this article addresses two themes: first, how global normative statements on "ownership" and "partnerships" for aid delivery, as embodied in the 1990 "World Declaration on Education for All" (UNESCO 1990), the "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000), and the "Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness" (OECD 2005), influence policy formation processes affecting quality; and second, how normative interpretations of EFA have been framed globally and then deployed in national-level processes and statements.

The article has two main sections. In the first section, I outline transdisciplinary CDA methodology for comparative education research. After locating the research in global and normative contexts for educational development, I discuss issues for quality in education. Then I reaffirm the relevance of critical development theory for elucidating power dynamics in educational development policy processes.

In the second section, I report on the application of CDA to the educational development policy contexts of Cambodia and Laos. I compare different actors' influences through intertextually related discursive mechanisms and documents, which represent and sustain an EFA "genre chain" for educational development (Fairclough 2003).

This research recognizes a "problem of how to go beyond the existing order of knowledge while being obliged simultaneously to work within its frameworks" (Tikly 2004, 192). In spite of gains experienced by some in the context of contemporary development approaches, I reiterate the continued need to substantiate limited, nominal policy "partnerships" and realize national "ownership" for mitigating, if not eradicating, associated inequities. I argue that institutionalized, substantive engagement of civil society, including comparative educators, continues to represent a potent avenue for progressive discursive (enacted and written) models.

CDA for Understanding Education as "Development"

Discourse and language play central roles in constructing the contemporary social world (Luke 2000; Fairclough 2003; Vavrus and Seghers 2010). Construction, dissemination, and reiteration of particular norms through policy mechanisms and documents are integral to processes of transferring ideas and strategies. Discourses constitute processes by which particular agendas and assumptions become embedded in social practices (Fairclough 2003). Powerful donors exert significant influence on governments in setting agendas for, then designing, funding, and monitoring, development projects and

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education programs. Tracing contextual, including written, channels of discursive education policy influence addresses "uncertainty about how the conduits of traveling policy operate from the global through to the national" (Ozga and Lingard 2007, 69). Geographical levels discussed are far from discrete (Bray et al. 2007), themselves products of discursive processes. Individuals and organizations work simultaneously across domains, feeding information and ideas in multiple directions.

CDA is the methodological approach employed in this study for a number of reasons. A critical analysis of language can reveal ways that the transmission of educational development norms between global and regional institutions and nations, through EFA, shapes educational development policies, particularly in relation to how quality is conceived. The document analysis component of CDA entails application of analytical tools based on Norman Fairclough's (2003) adaptation of systemic functional linguistics. Central methods include deconstructing documents' external and internal semantic elements and relationships for identifying assumptions, discourses, and omissions, and applying concepts of intertextuality and genre (see also Halliday and Hasan 1989; Vavrus and Seghers 2010).

Intertextuality and recontextualization across genres reinforce particular ideas and modes of communication in policy transfer through multiple levels, the latter through "genre chains" (Fairclough 2003). Genre chains comprise activities and documents of different genres, but oriented toward interrelated social phenomena. Examples of some elements in the EFA genre chain are conferences, documents, and workshops. They conform to particular generic characteristics but may also comprise hybrid or multiple genres. Transfer between, and combinations of, genres result in the recontextualization and naturalization of ideas and language.

For the nontextual aspects of CDA, including policy contexts and formation mechanisms, I adopted an "ethnographic epistemological approach" to fieldwork (Blommaert 2010, 187). Observation and semistructured interviews in English were conducted between 2007 and 2009.[1] Ten informants in Cambodia and nine in Laos were identified through a combination of purposive and opportunistic sampling of academic, government, bilateral, multilateral, and international nongovernmental organization (NGO) and NGO educational development stakeholders.[2]

[1] Based on the scope of the research, and that EFA policy forum meetings are conducted (and documents produced) in English at national, regional, and global levels, I decided to conduct interviews in English. Although the focus of this research has been on transfer between global, regional, and national policy activities, the lack of interviews and documents in Khmer and Lao represents a limitation, especially in terms of subnational policy processes.

[2] My research in the region included 104 informants across 6 countries: Cambodia, Laos, Indonesia, the Philippines, Papua New Guinea, and Vanuatu. The process of informant selection for interviews supporting document analysis entailed three stages. First, I analyzed primary and secondary educational development literature in order to identify the main policy actors in each country. These documents were: the EFA National Action Plans, the EFA 2000 Assessments, country plans for the bilateral and

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Hence, Allan Luke's (2002) elegant summation that "if there is a generalizable approach to CDA, then, it is this orchestrated and recursive movement between text and context" (100). However, a further step in emphasizing documents as an aspect of context foregrounds their instantiating and "normalizing" functions in policy struggles for inclusion and power. Central documents framing educational development policies include national constitutions, EFA national action plans and national development plans, and associated peripheral texts. Identifying documents' influence on the quality of education includes analyzing their external properties, recognizing them as cultural and social objects. It entails asking: Who is involved in their construction—how and when? What assumptions underpin their content? Which discourses motivate language types contained in documents? Analysis of their treatment of education-related content means identifying whether prioritization and/or exclusion of topics or EFA goals are evident, and how and by whom issues are defined and framed.

I view policy documents as an "outcome of political struggles over meaning" (Taylor 1997, 26). I emphasize the inherently political nature of policy formation by considering ways policies are forged from struggles between actors and approaches, and characterized through omission, by the work of those excluded from official processes. In characterizing "policy as the politics of discourse," Sandra Taylor foregrounds "the linkages between the various levels of the policy process with an emphasis on highlighting power relations" (1997, 34, 32). The combination of document and contextual analysis in CDA captures the socially constructed nature of policy issues occurring in given contexts to "determine whose interests they serve" (Gale 2001, 383). Emphasis on the formulation of policy at formal and informal "sites of engagement" reveals the effects of the marginalization of civil society contributions, and of EFA goals beyond UPE and gender, on quality.

The Global in National Policy Processes

Challenges inherent in investigating the still decidedly national terrains of global education initiatives receive considerable attention. The state remains significant at all levels of policy formation, albeit within reconfigured networks of actors (Deacon 2006). Rather than signaling their retreat, states have modified functions in light of processes identified as globalization, their role rendered more interactive in negotiating domestic issues now addressed

multilateral agencies listed, and other academic and NGO material where available. I then contacted organizations (almost all based in national capitals) by e-mail about 6 weeks before scheduled field work trips and then again the week before in cases where there had been no reply. The e-mail included a summary of the research and a participant consent form. On arrival, another round of e-mails was sent, and I contacted organizations by telephone. In no case was a negative reply received; either there was no reply to e-mail or telephone messages or my contact resulted in an interview. Interviews were held at agency offices or in the Ministries, unless otherwise specified, and were with one representative, unless indicated otherwise in parentheses in table A1 in the appendix.

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globally (Held et al. 1999). Linda Weiss (2003, 302) observes that "the normative and organizational configuration of institutions play a key role in conditioning the way states respond to globalization pressures . . . [and] shared norms can mediate the impacts of globalization." Rather than merely responding to external imperatives, nations (themselves historical, social constructs) retain prior, although not necessarily unchanging, sets of social and political influences and standards.

"Cohesive elites," because of their background and personal aspirations, may gravitate to what are identified as Western or global norms and, thus, influence policy choices in such directions. Understanding "elite cohesion" as "an important factor often sidelined in discussions of institutional change" is compelling in terms of domestic power dynamics within shifting postcolonial global power relations (Weiss 2003, 303–4). Alternately, political jockeying and other influences may disrupt cohesive impulses. Implicit here is the astute question of whether EFA policies aim for the "all" they claim to, or just "the smartest poor" (Abadzi 2004). Equally, interpreting elite corruption and transparency involves multiple understandings of class, geography, and politics, which reinforce prioritization of certain norms—for example, kinship ties. Important, too, is understanding the reach of the state apparatus, particularly regarding welfare and competing patronage systems.

Processes identified as globalization must be understood as not only economic, but rather involving varying combinations of political, social, cultural, and technological dynamics, extending through normative and organizational structures from supranational levels to communities (Held et al 1999). For example, Jenny Ozga and Bob Lingard (2007, 69) posit that "globalised policy agendas and processes interact with traditions, ideologies, institutions and politics that have developed on national terrains." Thus, critically investigating the prominent role of international organizations as "norm entrepreneurs" or "social engineers" (Finnemore and Sikkink 1998; Nederveen Pieterse 1998) in educational development policy construction is essential in light of compelling evidence that they "may actually shape the policy preferences of states by changing what states want" (Barnett and Finnemore 2004, 11; Risse et al. 1999).

Normative Agendas and EFA in Global Perspective

Norms can be understood as intersubjective standards, including shared beliefs and accepted practice (Finnemore and Sikkink 1998). They model the way their proponents think aspects of life should or ought to be. Deconstruction of how EFA-related norms are diffused globally and regionally through discursive channels illuminates how norms are accommodated, altered, reflected, and/or rejected in relation to the multiple objectives influencing education policies. Analysis of legitimacy accorded to various norm carriers can clarify understanding of levels of education policy autonomy and

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influence. Conversely, national compliance with, and/or adaptation of, global initiatives not only reflects the need for funding, but also for legitimacy in the eyes of the international community (Chabbott 2003).

The institutionalized norms underpinning the EFA movement have been "accreting" for over a century (Mundy 1998, 2007; Chabbott 2003). They have been formalized through United Nations conventions, and then refashioned in 1990 as a global program for educational development at the World Conference for EFA at Jomtien. The "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000) and Millennium Development Goals (MDGs; UN 2000) saw them cemented in global targets. Key EFA-related norms include: education as an individual human right; education as a fundamental component of national development and/or economic growth; early childhood care and education (ECCE); formal, universal, and free primary education; adult literacy; life skills and technical and vocational education; gender equality; and quality of education.

Global Normative Statements on "Ownership" and "Partnerships" in Aid Policy

Global and regional EFA policy activities and documents represent links in a genre chain instantiating and maintaining institutional norms discursively. UN and other multilateral donor assessments, conferences, and planning sessions are conducted in regional and subregional groupings, as well as nationally. Regional networks of actors and agencies share information and strategies at conferences, study tours, and workshops organized by donors and have been instrumental in bringing about and disseminating "harmonization" dialogue. Two examples are sector-wide approaches (SWAps) as policy mechanisms, or EFA Mid-decade Assessment processes. Whether organization on a regional basis may supersede more formal globalized forms of policy cooperation, as has been speculated (Deacon 2006, 144), it does not reflect the current situation of mutually reinforcing regional and global processes.

The beginning of this millennium marked another discursive shift for development policy processes, ostensibly aimed at fulfilling decades of "participation" promises (Cornwall and Brock 2006); global and national rhetoric identifies civil society participation as essential (UNESCO 2000; OECD 2005). Another aspect concerns harmonization, or reducing donor duplication, with the "new" aims and roles of educational development stakeholders being detailed in the "Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness" (OECD 2005). Major donors—or "development partners"—and recipients, including Cambodia and Laos, have signed this and related influential normative statements.

The terms "partnership" and "ownership" are central to EFA harmonization endeavors but remain contested (OECD 2005). "Partnerships" represent an unspecified array of unequal bilateral and multilateral relationships between combinations of actors at different levels (Vavrus and Seghers 2010).

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"Ownership," while regularly acknowledged as a precondition for the quality and sustainability of aid interventions, is often considered too strong a term given concern over weak state financial and governance capacity and is regularly substituted by "leadership." For instance, in spite of the rhetoric stipulating government ownership, SWAps have been donor initiated and led, with leadership being associated with levels of finance and related power of "lead" donors.

Quality Education(s) for All

Cultural, political, and social factors, inseparable from resource constraints, (should) have considerable effects on education strategies, particularly in determining what quality means. Thus, the uniformity of global institutional development approaches is noteworthy given such variation within communities. There is a "lack of regulation regarding imported educational methods and standards" and a parallel lack of a national—and, importantly, subnational—"dialogue about what quality and relevance mean" (Courtney 2007, 558).

A local NGO informant in Phnom Penh observed that donor funding is delinked from performance, so incentives to improve local "capacity" are lower. This is compounded by the allure of perks related to donor "workshopping" culture—that is, frequent educational development information-sharing and strategizing meetings, seminars, and trips, at multiple levels. Cambodian development practitioners Meas Nee and Joan Healy (2004, 44) observe that "donors who talk of 'capacity development' frequently mean the skills to manage aid projects, rather than the capacity to analyze the circumstances and advise about the aid most suited to the community."

The implications of these perspectives for achieving a nationally and locally relevant consensus on what constitutes quality in education are striking. They reveal language at cross purposes. Although the ramifications of using another language, and the capacity to be critical of global/Western policy or legal document conventions and tropes, are beyond the scope of this article, the challenges engendered in English as the global language for education policies cannot be overstated. In addition, access to documents, even where they are translated, is available only to those either near a provincial center (even then not guaranteed) or with access to the Internet.

Overarching factors affecting the quality of education include: poverty; health; governmental, financial, and political systems, and related institutional configurations; population increase and demography; welfare systems; corruption; and the nature of available data. Central to educational quality is the supply, perceived role, training, and treatment of teachers (UNESCO 2004). Factors determining and supporting teachers' work include: curriculum content, especially relevance to location; pedagogy; classroom condi-

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tions; teacher-student ratios; learning materials and learning time; and implicit organization and prioritization processes.

Within the EFA framework, the interrelated nature of a national education system and, beyond the formal system, the uses and value of literacy as articulated by community members, are understood clearly to affect the quality of education. However, this remains in tension with long-standing institutional discourses prizing basic, formal education to bolster human capital and economic growth for poverty reduction. Human capital approaches continue to dominate donor and government activity, through discursive and practical emphasis on UPE in the MDGs and EFA Fast Track Initiative. Additional criticisms include a focus on those countries most likely to succeed, and increased conditions for neoliberal reform of financial and educational systems. Approaches include decentralization, privatization, and democratic governance, paradoxically combined with a neglect of key aspects of those systems—for example, early childhood care and education, adult literacy, and nongovernment actors.

Challenges in measuring quality have been well rehearsed, for example, relating to the OECD (Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development) and PISA (Programme for International Student Assessment) tables (Ozga and Lingard 2007, 68; Alexander 2008; OECD 2008). Variations within nations can be extreme and obscured. Ranking means that some countries and provinces must come last and, as charged in even those considered the most developed of education systems, can encourage a focus on results at the expense of relevance and quality, particularly when determined by those unfamiliar, and sometimes only superficially engaged, with context. From a critical perspective, such comparisons exemplify what Leon Tikly (2004, 182) identified as "a mechanism both to know and, hence, control the populations of these countries."

Debates oscillate between whether quality should be addressed once universal access has been achieved, or whether disillusionment in the face of poor quality exacerbates dropout, low achievement, and parental distrust of formal education, especially where direct and opportunity costs are highest. Attention to effects on quality through education levels has increased, resulting, for example, in particular (rhetorical) emphasis on the early childhood care and education dimension in EFA Mid-decade Assessments (MoEYS 2007). While interest and rhetoric are abundant, funding has not been, with work conducted by the same few international NGOs—Save the Children and Plan International—along with UNICEF. Simultaneously, as global and governmental encouragement of a dominant role for the private sector increases, so does concern over the lack of agreed-upon standards and poor quality with related inequality of access.

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Framing Normative Processes in Critical Development Theory

Some critical development theorists have posited that development as an industry sustains neocolonial agendas and structures supporting global inequity (Tucker 1999). Common to critical theory approaches is the challenge to power imbalances, present in both structural and agential approaches. With a history taking in Paulo Freire's "conscientization"—and, in development more broadly, "dependency" theories that offered an antidote to modernization, only to lose speed to human capital approaches—education and development are recognized as *political* pursuits. Implicit in this is our ability to alter and influence processes and their outcomes, which are key aims of employing CDA.

The linguistic and textual mechanics of development processes perpetuate exclusion. Development-speak is accessible only to those most embedded in its rapidly evolving discourse and paper trails. Through powerful actors' deployment of "buzzwords" (Cornwall and Brock 2006) and an obfuscating proliferation of quarterly, midterm, annual, and other project documents that culminate in a kind of "acronymania," a development dialect has emerged. The conventions of this dialect must be rapidly assimilated in order to understand, let alone be heard in, development circles. For some critical theorists, framing this is the "linguistic imperialism" associated with English(es) as a global lingua franca (Phillipson 2008). Such developments put most at a double remove from decisions determining the course of their lives.

In recalling critical development theory from a "twilight zone" in the midst of neoliberal policyscapes, Frans Schuurman (2009) details some conflicting schools of thought as to whether those adopting its positions should be required to offer alternatives to shortcomings identified in mainstream approaches. Of those attempting to do so, Jan Nederveen Pieterse (1998) builds on the work of Vincent Tucker (1999) in positing a "Tao of Development," lamenting that at this stage in history, improved involvement of richer nations is preferable to none. Nederveen Pieterse (2006) emphasizes holism and bottom-up approaches, through to more recent globalization-related work on "emancipatory cosmopolitanism," as distinct from mainstream versions. Balanced, broadly inclusive, and adaptive approaches are prized.

Critical theory perspectives in related fields provide important insights. In international relations, John Hobson (2007) calls for a "post-racist" critical theory, cautioning against Eurocentrism even within critical theoretical traditions. Economist Ben Fine critiques the dominant "zombie economics" for development, based "on optimizing individuals in single-minded pursuit of self-interest, embedded within formal mathematical models centered on (deviations from) efficiency and equilibrium, and reputedly tested against the evidence statistically" (2009, 886). Comparative education scholars high-

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light mental and physical legacies of colonialism evident in structures of education systems, curricula, and language of instruction (Hickling-Hudson 2000), outlining spaces for comparative education in a new "anti-imperial critical theory" (Tikly 2004).

Schuurman (2009) highlights the "sidelining" of the critical in academia and the neoliberal challenge to the crucial role of universities in fostering critical approaches, also evident in aid-agency funding of scholars (Deacon 2006). In addition, scholarships aimed at "building capacity" within nations are often provided by agencies promoting educational development norms that serve donor, elite, and global capitalist, economic interests.

Cambodia and Laos: Quality Education for All, or for Some More than Others?

In the remainder of this article, I present a critical discourse analysis of EFA policy documents and processes in the contexts of Cambodia and Laos, drawing on this theoretical framework. Having considered the global contexts for educational development, I outline contemporary and historical national contexts for education. Then I consider education policies prior to EFA. Subsequently, I analyze the composition and focus of EFA policy forums aligned with the "Paris Declaration" as components in an EFA genre chain. Next I offer an interpretation of national EFA documents, also seen as composing the genre chain, by analyzing the discourses and intertextuality between documents.

National Contexts for Education

The unevenly growing populations of Cambodia and Laos share intertwined histories of colonialism under the French, as well as civil and regional conflict, and navigate societies on limited, donor-dependent resource bases. Recent high levels of economic growth in both nations have seen domestic replication of the worldwide trend toward rising inequality, demonstrating differentiated standards of education dependent on ethnicity, gender, income, and/or location (Jalilian 2007). The governments of each explicitly enlist EFA in the service of economic growth, albeit ostensibly "pro-poor," and go further in embracing free-market ideals, yet neither has established comprehensive welfare systems supporting the economically and politically marginalized.

Historical and social dynamics are central to understanding education from systemic and individual perspectives. The role of Pagoda schools and Buddhist tradition influences quality through curricula, language, and ways that cultural and social norms have prohibited girls' involvement. Particular social norms are embedded, given that "within living memory people have lived through a regime where even the value of their lives was not respected by the state. The values of the reciprocal relationships of family and patronage assume more importance than do any broader responsibilities of community

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or nation" (Nee and Healy 2004, 39). Compounding this, "when corruption has become a social norm, attempts to eradicate this problem are extremely difficult" (34), especially where "the military patronage system is a particular social group that has been bonded strongly by this form of corruption" (35–36) and continues to exert power through ruling party infrastructure. In addition to fragile environments, the educational consequences of more than three quarters of the educated having been killed, been tortured, or fled are unquantifiable (Duggan 1996; Dy and Ninomiya 2003).

Contrasting characteristics, in light of uniform educational development approaches, are significant for comparison of EFA policies: population size (with Cambodia almost three times as populous); ethnic makeup (Laos with significant diversity); geography (Laos' mountainous, landlocked/landlinked terrain presents specific challenges); economy (increasing Cambodian oil revenues make equitable distribution more urgent, while as a "Highly Indebted Poor Country," Laos attempts to access resources); politics (national identity, democratic involvement, reform trajectories); and governance (degrees of institutionalization).

Beyond this, diversity exists within Cambodia and Laos, as in every nation, province, and small community: "The social pattern of a particular village needs to be considered and taken into account in any consideration of change. . . . Wealth, power, gender and education have particular significance in village culture and shape the social order in such a way that it is almost impossible for those without power to find justice" (Nee and Healy 2004, 10).

Education Policies and Quality Pre-EFA?

Lao government education statements prior to EFA during the 1980s were highly political, with nation-building being their primary aim. Party recommendations and decrees were dispensed to line ministries, whose job in turn was "to organize the implementation of all resolutions and orders of the Party's Central Committee and the Government" (LPDRMoE 1993, 1). The goals of mass literacy and UPE by 1985 under the education component of the Five Year Plan were not achieved, in part because of resources, but also because factors associated with quality (language, teachers, textbooks, and practice) were not incorporated. Government-wide reform initiated according to the New Economic Mechanism in 1986, and again in 1991 to reverse problems associated with decentralization, entailed promoting education along market-oriented lines, although retaining state socialist ideology (Adams et al. 2001).

In 1990, a representative of the Lao Ministry of Education (LPDRMoE) attended the World Conference on EFA. The EFA movement precipitated the first national education policy; no comprehensive sector policy had been

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articulated previously by the state. The Medium Term Policy Framework for Basic Education in 1995 represented the EFA strategy prior to the current EFA National Action Plans (AusAID 2005). The Lao government end-of-decade EFA review is unequivocal about the influence of EFA on national education discourse and policy: "The main EFA events and action since 1990 included the promulgation and the implementation of the Lao PDR Constitution in 1991 (Article 19) relative to compulsory education" (LPDRMoE 2000, 18). Having identified formal education as central to national identity, the EFA 2000 Assessment goes on to outline primary education projects by international financial institutions the World Bank (WB) and Asian Development Bank (ADB) and by "like-minded" bilateral donors. Vocational training was supported by UNESCO, UNDP, and UNICEF; nonformal education was attributed to international NGOs. Quality features in a WB project providing textbooks and teacher training, with an objective to "revise and upgrade the previous primary and lower secondary curriculum and rewrite the content *to complement with the national socio-economic development plan*" (LPDRMoE 2000, 24; emphasis added).

In Cambodia, the main focus pre-EFA through the 1980s was also "rehabilitation" in access to education, with the Vietnamese system as a model under occupation until 1989 (Dy and Ninomiya 2003). Vietnamese advisors wrote policy documents for the Ministry, objectives being "good technical" and "political training," and "Eastern bloc" countries seconded professors (Clayton 2005, 510). A senior education official noted, "We just tried to open school and literacy classes—we didn't care about quality" (Dy and Ninomiya 2003, 6).

At war until 1991, Cambodia's first election was in 1993; civil war persisted through the decade. In the transition from a centrally planned economy to the free-market economy of the 1990s, education served to address "different socioeconomic realities" (MoEYS 1994; Dy and Ninomiya 2003). After a Ministry of Education, Youth and Sport (MoEYS) representative attended the World Conference on EFA in 1990, UNESCO and UNICEF supported the EFA "basic education conceptual framework" from 1991 (Dy and Ninomiya 2003). The first national policy was "prepared in common by the [MoEYS] and a team of international experts," under a UNDP project, citing EFA as its foundation (MoEYS 2000). A consultant at those first national policy framework meetings in 1994 argues that even in the brief period of formal education prior to war (1953–73), there was "dual development" of education in the lack of integration between state and religious schools, resulting in central and provincial disparities still evident today (Duggan 1996, 364). The government's employment of a "discourse of destruction" to "justify the conditions of the present" has been linked with overwhelming aid influxes, which has become "a pattern consistently repeated . . . by consultants and international organizations since" (Ayres 2000, 207–8).

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EFA Policy Coordination: Nominal "Ownership," Unequal "Partnerships"

Drawing on fieldwork interviews and observation for the contextual component of CDA,[3] I consider in this section the composition and roles of policy groups in Cambodia and Laos, treating arrangements and meetings as social elements combining with documents in formation of a discursive EFA genre chain. I report on an analysis of actors' relationships within educational development policy processes, framed by the global norms of the "World Declaration on Education for All," the "Dakar Framework for Action" and the "Paris Declaration," and national organization around SWAp mechanisms intended to realize these principles.

The donor-led Education Sector Working Group in Cambodia is particularly well-evolved institutionally within a broader national infrastructure under the Council for the Development of Cambodia. Although the group has 12 official members, bilateral donor informants noted that only four or five regularly attend, with regional donors China and Japan conspicuously absent. Multilateral and bilateral donor interviewees identified a lack of consensus and a focus on technical issues, specifically over the budget support modality, with its strongest proponents—the European Community, Asian Development Bank, and World Bank—perceived as dominating debate. A local NGO representative observed that "more money" meant "more voice" and government time (Informant). Other bilateral and multilateral donors interviewed cited intractable constraints in capacity, legal, and organizational factors.

Donor and NGO informants independently cited the "strong disconnect between planning and budgeting, between budgets and actual expenditures, and between expenditures and actual results," and decision making "outside formal planning processes" (NGO Forum on Cambodia 2006, 5; Informants). A UNICEF employee noted that materials were not circulated, or changes were distributed at the last minute. UNICEF and Save the Children employees observed similar characteristics of government decision-making processes in Laos (Informants).

In contrast to delayed formalization of a group in Laos, the Cambodian Education Sector Working Group has produced comprehensive annual reports since 2002. Although the SWAp, initiated in 2000, had gained broader support after initial skepticism among both government and some donors, informants were mixed regarding enhanced "ownership." Government and UNICEF representatives recognized the benefits of information sharing, as well as the potential to reduce overlap of endeavors and government time spent meeting with donors (Informants). However, a UNICEF employee stated that initial added organizational time and transaction costs for donors and government were deflecting from educational concerns and quality im-

[3] Due to the relatively small and overlapping pool of agencies and individuals, and the politically sensitive nature of development relationships, interviewees are not named but identified by agency. See also n. 2 above.

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peratives, without a sense of when, or whether, these would be reduced (Informant). Another local NGO employee saw tensions between understanding of local issues by those at "post," and donor governments motivated by national interest, as being mitigated by coordination efforts (Informant).

According to Cambodia's EFA Mid-decade Assessment:

> In the watershed year 2000, a new approach *was proposed* to frame the relationship between Cambodia and the agencies providing development assistance. The shift *was to be* from "donorship to partnership." This paradigm shift "*drove* the Ministry of Education Youth and Sport (MoEYS) and its partners toward the SWAp process in the education sector" (CDC, "Practices and Lessons Learned in the Management of Development Cooperation: Case Studies in Cambodia," Para. 6.1). The Sector-Wide Approach *was introduced* through a seminar held by UNICEF/SIDA in 2000. The *introduction of the approach* included all stakeholders and stressed an *acknowledgement* of Government leadership in setting priorities for the sector. (MoEYS 2007, 4–5; emphasis added)

"Ownership" is rendered ambiguous through use of the passive voice (italicized above) and, ironically, a promised shift away from "donorship" itself externally imposed. If it was the "paradigm shift" that "drove" the Ministry, then who, in turn, drove the paradigm shift? Skepticism concerning the extent of international bureaucratic influence on EFA and education policy is evident in shadow reports and comments from the NGO community regarding the "alphabet soup with many different planning instruments, each with an English language acronym" (NGO Forum on Cambodia 2006, 4).

Regarding the "capacity" of those in the Ministry, government and multilateral informants repeatedly observed that most in the current generation of policy makers were not only deprived of education but also accustomed to exceptional cultural, military, and social norms influencing how and why policy decisions are made. One UNICEF informant was hopeful that capable younger officials were starting to come up through the system, although one local NGO representative cautioned that the "hierarchical" nature of Cambodian society may preclude significant contributions to change (Informants).

Rapid institutionalization of "coordination" has been influenced by Cambodia being selected by the OECD as 1 of 14 pilot countries in the monitoring scheme for aid "harmonization." The OECD identifies itself with a normative position emphasizing economic growth through educating for human capital, albeit with recent rhetorical turns to "sustainability" and "social development" and, as discussed, trades in statistical, competitive interpretations of education systems (OECD 2008). Along the lines of the World Bank, the OECD also promotes private-sector-led involvement for preschool and higher education. The World Bank is the leading agency, or focal point, for donor coordination processes in education in Cambodia; with the European Union, it promotes budget support and leads EFA Fast Track Initiative processes.

Channels for institutionalized civil society contribution to national edu-

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cation policy processes have improved significantly since 2000, when the NGO Education Partnership was formed. This NGO education coalition is positioned within a broader development coalition, the NGO Forum on Cambodia, and is represented in the Education Sector Working Group. The education coalition links with the main regional NGO, the Asia South Pacific Association for Basic and Adult Education, and the Global Campaign for Education. Such linkages are vital for information sharing, legitimizing, and funding the promotion of sidelined EFA areas including quality, and related adult literacy, ECCE, and special needs education (DVV International 2008).

However, one local NGO employee observed that, collectively, NGOs have little real power in terms of formal policy development but that respected individuals are able to influence government decisions. For instance, the NGO recommendations presented on inclusive education and relevance were not included in policy documents (Informants; NGO Forum on Cambodia 2006). NGOs and the government have struggled regarding EFA approaches, with the two working on parallel streams. NGOs are perceived to neglect the national scope of development endeavors, and central government to be downplaying local needs (Nee and Healy 2004, 50). The same NGO informant described a split in the Ministry regarding the necessity of NGO collaboration, and its tendency to compete for donor resources for UPE and other EFA goals determining, and including, quality.

Normative Tensions and "Harmonization" Laos

High levels of financial and procedural dependency on donors are evident in Laos in the area of EFA and education policy formation and implementation. Formal primary education and gender, as per the MDGs, represent the focus of major donor activities, with ECCE, adult literacy, and special needs funded by international NGOs.

A donor working group was formalized in 2008, with Ministry liaison, but there is no SWAp, in spite of ongoing discussions and negotiation since 2000 (Tibi 2006). ADB, UNICEF, and international NGO (INGO) employees suggested that wariness related to interpretation of the concept, perceived lack of technical capacity, as well as individual personalities have contributed to comparative resistance (Informants; Regeringskansliet 2003). Disagreement regarding the potential scope (formal basic education or whole sector) and levels of collaboration of key actors has contributed to shifts in responsibility for maintaining the process.

AusAID and UNICEF have so far shared the leading role in the Education Sector Working Group. The ADB's Sector Development Framework was explicitly not called a SWAp for the reasons noted above. This replaced the Swedish International Development Agency (SIDA) SWAp attempt and complicated a protracted donor and government EFA Fast Track Initiative application debacle (Informants). SIDA had been a long-standing donor in

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Laos, particularly to education, but in 2011 will complete the withdrawal process that began in 2008, justified through a global reconfiguration of the agency's work. However, documentation reveals repeated and strong reference to, and continuance of aid contingent on, human rights and corruption improvements by the state (Regeringskansliet 2003).

The state-affiliated Lao Women's Union and Lao People's Revolutionary Youth Union officially represent civil society in Laos. Independent local NGOs are not legally recognized. Important civil society engagement in EFA policy formation and critiques, discussed in relation to Cambodia and found elsewhere in the region, is nonexistent. There is a significant international NGO presence, represented in the donor working group through a member of the International NGO Network that, while strictly monitored by the state, is able to exercise strong autonomy regarding project content (ADB 2005; Informants). One Save the Children employee felt that, while useful for updating and disseminating information, the network was sporadic and presented difficulty reconciling disparate interests. A local ADB employee distinguished international NGOs in Laos as less "advocacy-based" and "more like development agencies" (Informant).

In terms of education policy relationships, a UNICEF employee surmised that as long as funds were provided and no challenges to government or official statements were made, donors had a free hand in dealing with educational design and details. Internal bureaucratic power struggles at times determine policy outcomes, often in spite of rhetoric.[4] International NGO and multilateral donors perceived differing cultural approaches and language issues as contributing to challenges in negotiations. For example, multiple informants noted the absence of a culture of debate in discussions with ministry officials, with meetings consisting of presentations and limited question time, and international NGO donor employees reported regular state censorship of Lao materials but not those in English. One from Plan International described the government approach as "a-historical" and "technical," as a culture of "coordination rather than collaboration" (Informant). Another international NGO employee observed that the government seemed to be "shamed" into agreeing on taking initiatives. A World Bank staff member recognized difficulties for younger government staff in challenging the seniority-based hierarchical culture. A Save the Children representative noted that while "on paper" the government controls all, including the private sector, donor funding mostly goes directly to projects or provinces. Similarly, a UNICEF employee observed that although policies have been written, action or debate does not follow.

[4] I am grateful to an external reviewer for emphasizing this point.

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Normative Statements, EFA, and the State in Laos

The previous section considered contextual analysis of evolving policy formation mechanisms for EFA and "loose coupling" evident in discourses promoting comprehensive ownership and partnerships (Chabbott 2003). Prior sections discussed nontextual normative discursive elements in the genre chain (conferences, meetings, policy groups, workshops, etc.). This section situates EFA in the historical and political contexts of forging two "modern" nations. It reports on document analysis of the national constitutions, and the documents' construction contexts, tracing ways these are linked intertextually with EFA documentation and discourses. The way Cambodian and Lao national constitutions are interwoven in an EFA genre chain with respective EFA 2000 Reviews, EFA National Action Plans, and EFA Mid-decade Assessment is linked to national development discourses, as are specific aspects of their intertextual reinforcement. Table 1 summarizes the main national documents that are found in the genre chain extending from the establishment of EFA in 1990. National and regional EFA End of Decade Review processes, underway at the time of writing, are among the most recent additional links in the chain, as is this article.

The controversy surrounding the formation of the current constitution of Laos is instructive regarding the normative role of written policy texts in linking education, national governance, and identity in political context, with global influence. According to Amnesty International, although a committee was established with the aid of East German advisors in the 1970s, Laos's constitution was not produced and adopted prior to Western, or international, pressure in the 1980s: "International development agencies were reluctant to invest in Laos given the absence of a fixed, knowable law. Amnesty International, in a 1985 report on Laos, asserted that without a constitution or published penal and criminal codes, citizens were 'effectively denied proper legal guarantees of their internationally recognized human rights.'" (Amnesty International, n.d.) Promulgation of the constitution in 1990 sparked anti-corruption and prodemocracy protests calling for a multiparty system, which were promptly squashed in spite of clauses in the constitution guaranteeing freedom of speech, and then repeated in 2003 to the same response.

Ostensibly, then, articulating the normative underpinnings of the state, in the direction of "socialism and democracy," the constitution identifies "modernization" and "industrialization" as national values, with a distinctly outward-looking, market orientation (Lao PDR 2003). Individual and nation are explicitly linked through education; "science" education is emphasized for growth, as in the "World Declaration on Education for All" (UNESCO 1990) and the "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000, 77). Articles 21–25, notably new additions in the 2003 version of the Lao PDR Constitution, speak directly and indirectly to educational quality: "The state attends to developing education and implements compulsory primary education in or-

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TABLE 1
National Normative Documents for EFA

Country	National Constitution	National Development Plan	EFA 2000 Assessment	EFA National Action Plan	EFA Mid-decade Assessment	Civil Society Shadow Reports
Cambodia	1993; 1979; 1975; 1953	Socio-Economic Development Plan (SEDP) I (1996); SEDPII (2001); National Poverty Reduction Strategy (2003)	1999: Cites promulgation of 1993 constitution under "EFA-related activities"; 1994 first sector policy	2003: EFANAP is the second national sector policy	2007	Multiple, regular NGO Education Partnership reports; institutionalized role in education review process
Laos	2003; 1990; 1947 (French)	NGPES (2004); NSEDP (2005)	1999: "EFA events and action: the promulgation & implementation of 1991 Lao Constitution"	2005: First comprehensive national sector policy, adopted as "major EFA event/activity"	2008	None

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der to *build* good citizens with revolutionary competence, knowledge and abilities. The state and society attend to developing high quality national education to create opportunities and favorable conditions in *education for all* people throughout the country, especially people in *remote* areas, ethnic groups, women and disadvantaged children. The state promotes *private sector investment* in the development of *national* education in accordance with the laws" (Lao PDR 2003, article 22; emphasis added). Three salient points with normative implications for educational quality can be drawn from this: emphasis on the ideological, political role of formal education for the state and related nation-building focus; the importance formally accorded to the private sector in education; and formal recognition of marginalized sectors of society. The role of the state as provider is emphasized, denoted through repeated use of "the state" and "attends," with compliance and a moral dimension implied in the use of "good." Imprints of global development discourse are evident in the italicized phrases. The references to "remote areas, ethnic groups, women and disadvantaged groups" echo later phases of development discourse (Chabbott 2003). The absence of other aspects of discourse, for example, adult literacy or social justice elements, is also significant. The foregrounding of private sector investment and formal education for growth conform to neoliberal approaches stipulated by the Asian Development Bank, World Bank, and like-minded bilateral donors.

Recognition of minority languages is one area in which constitutional guarantee of "opportunities and favorable conditions" had not been supported until early in 2008. The official state language is spoken by roughly 50 percent of the population, meaning of those children actually in primary school, half learn in a second language, with glaring implications for quality and retention (Adams 2001). Representatives of multilateral organizations and international NGOs consulted interpret EFA as having a positive influence on policy in this area, incrementally moving to a stage where dialogue is entertained and allowing for limited use of mother-tongue teaching in preschool.

Neoliberal discourse is again employed in linking formal education to national development policy through pro-poor strategies in the Laos National Growth and Poverty Eradication Strategy (Lao PDR 2006), a document required by the World Bank for funding. Global normative influence and orientation are referenced explicitly in the Laos EFA National Plan, where "government has collaborated with the donor community to develop the [Strategy]" (LPDRMoE 2005, 39). Moreover: "The 'Education Strategic Vision by 2010 and 2020' issued by the MOE in 2000 links education to broader socio-economic development, as well as to the immediate local situation. . . . The document clearly aims to *incorporate "international" trends and standards* in to the Lao PDR, and to develop all levels of education systematically and continually—including strengthening the role of the *private sector* in the pro-

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TABLE 2
Breakdown of Intertextual References in EFA National Action Plans

Document	Cambodia	Laos
Jomtien Declaration	2	0
"Dakar Framework"/targets	17	5
UN conventions	3	1
MDGs	6	5
Regional	3	0
National constitution/decree	2	4
Other/subnational EFA plan	21	10
Poverty Reduction Strategy Paper	9	15
Medium Term Expenditure Framework	9	25
National education policies	48	11
National development policies	6	2
International academic research	1	0
International agency research	7	0
National research	13	2

Note.—Figures represent the frequency of references. Under "UN conventions": for Cambodia, two references are to the Convention on the Rights of the Child, and one is to the Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW); for Laos, one reference is made to the Convention on the Rights of the Child. EFA = Education for All; MDG = Millennium Development Goal.

vision of education. In general, the *strategic vision* seeks to *mobilize* education as a core component in overall *human resources development* for the development of the Lao PDR" (LPDRMoE 2005, 37). Implications in Laos of a focus on humans as capital, overriding concerns of quality and relevance, are evident, including insufficient monitoring of private sector involvement, demonstrated particularly in the area of ECCE. Private provision is limited mainly to the urban 10–15 percent of the population who can access and afford better facilities, teachers, and quality.

In addition to private sector promotion, other characteristics of neoliberal discourse here include the corporatization of policy language, and mixing of policy and corporate-strategy genres (evident in government and donor documents, as well as above), in keeping with "international" trends and "standards," and "human resources development."

Intertextuality among documents, reinforcing discourses not only within the education sector but also in cross-sectoral development documentation, is extensive (see table 2). Reiteration of "development" four times in three lines above indicates its centrality as a nation-building project. The self-reflexive note in the EFA National Action Plan that "the document aims to incorporate 'international' trends" may be understood as a message of agreement with donors and the international community, in line with the "Dakar Framework for Action," in seeking financing as well as legitimation.

Analysis of both countries' EFA National Action Plans reveals a close adherence to the "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000) guidelines in content, language, and structure. Cambodia's is a dense, highly polished document with full costing and quality conceptualized as a cross-cutting theme. That of Laos, while professionally presented, has a notably less polished layout and is narrower in scope. Quality is addressed principally in

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relation to formal education. Table 2 reflects the density of intertextual referencing exhibited in the Cambodian plan, as well as the strong links with national policies and EFA initiatives. This is in contrast to Laos's thinner referencing but focus on global financial norms.

Both countries are signatories to the UN conventions supporting education from a universal, or global, human rights perspective. In terms of national legal frameworks for education, both countries have passed education laws requiring compulsory attendance and providing for free, basic formal education.

State Architecture for EFA in Cambodia

The Cambodian Constitution enlists "liberal democracy" and "pluralism" as ideological touchstones (RGC 1993). It goes further, also echoing the "World Declaration on Education for All" (UNESCO 1990) and the "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000) in specifying its guarantee of rights-based, quality education "according to the principle of *modern* pedagogy including *technology* and foreign languages. The State shall provide free primary and secondary *education to all citizens* in all public schools" (RGC 1993, articles 67 and 68; emphasis added). However, continued suppression associated with the ruling Cambodian People's Party, and ongoing allegations of corruption and delays in passing the draft Anticorruption and Education Laws, render the alignment of such normative statements with practice questionable (Hughes 2009). With 2008 elections having consolidated the Cambodian People's Party power, a situation prevails resonating with David Ayres's (2000) extensive work on historical, ongoing power dynamics between elites and others: "The increasingly institutionalized system of merits and honors awarded to *saboraschon* (meritorious benefactors of public works) operates through the party system to co-opt the vulnerable and marginalized into an intricate complex of economic and political control . . . render(ing) local government reliant on party financing for the bulk of their development funding, and entails that villagers increasingly cannot afford to vote against the [Cambodian People Party]" (Hughes 2009, 210–11). Furthermore, a local NGO employee and academic reported personal experiences of what was described as extensive elite corruption in relation to securing teachers' positions and educational administration (Informant).

As in Laos and most aid-receiving nations, Cambodia has an extensive donor-initiated architecture of sector plans, some written according to a provided template, all abbreviated to fuel the acronymania described above (see table 1). Implementation and financial aspects of the Education Strategic Plan are articulated in the Education Sector Support Programme, on which the National Socio-Economic Development Plan is based. The Medium Term Expenditure Framework and Sector-wide Policy Action Matrix, for donor-government collaboration, are additional to the well-regarded EFA National

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Action Plan and EFA Mid-decade Assessment. These, representing government education documents only, are but a few links in the EFA genre chain.

For Cambodia, education is central to one of four pillars in the National Socio-Economic Development Plan: "capacity building and human resource development." The pro-poor emphasis has been successful in boosting access, particularly for girls. However, the MoEYS acknowledges that this has been at the expense of quality (MoEYS 2007, 7). The focus in terms of EFA has been formal education, with continued marginalization of early childhood education and adult literacy, both intrinsically important but also imperative in supporting quality (MoEYS 2007).

In Cambodia's EFA Mid-decade Assessment, the intertextuality across the three frameworks for educational development policy is explicitly articulated, highlighting at least rhetorical conformity with global discourses, for funding:

> The EFA Framework for Action adopted in 2000 in Dakar, like the MDG, represents a global consensus on long-term targets that exerts a powerful *influence on the way donors organize their assistance*. . . . The EFA National Plan 2003–2015 is a product of the Royal Government of Cambodia *responding to agreements and commitments at a global level. Adopting the EFA framework generates a strong guarantee that global donor support for the achievement of these goals will be forthcoming.* The EFA National Plan 2003–2015 is thus akin to the subsequent National Strategic Development Plan 2006–2010, which incorporates the Cambodian Millennium Development Goals, and can rely on donor support to achieve the MDG targets. (MoEYS 2007, 6; emphasis added).

The emphasized expectation of reciprocal responsibility of donors for funding (lines 4–6 above) acts simultaneously to signify compliance and to remind donors of commitments, as stipulated in the "Dakar Framework for Action" (UNESCO 2000).

One implication concerning normative influences on educational quality emerging from this discussion of state approaches to documentation of policy is the "loose coupling" evident in relation to guarantees of rights and services. Access to formal, primary education is promoted in the service of growth, and private provision to the benefit of the few, at the expense of improving quality in education for the marginalized or even the poor majority. Pro-poor rhetoric and requirements, originating with multilateral and bilateral agencies working transnationally, and supported by elites nationally, emphasize neoliberal approaches (community provision, decentralization, and privatization) as corollaries to funding, echoing promises of equitable growth.

Conclusions

This article has emphasized the lack of national and subnational debate regarding what quality in education means for particular contexts. It has illustrated how education policy processes are cemented intertextually within an EFA genre chain of documentation and activities and justified through

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statistical evidence of increased formal schooling. Rather than embodying those principles of "harmonization," "participation," and national "ownership," and including substantive civil society input, my research has identified policy arrangements and documentation in Cambodia and Laos as forums for reproducing power imbalances sustaining national elite political interests, and dominant global agendas, through their composition and functions. The exclusion of actors and nonformal elements of EFA have been perpetuated to differing degrees in both countries. While resource limitations are clear, analyzing imbalances reveals normative motivations behind focusing on UPE and gender aspects of EFA, particularly in contexts of high dependency on donors' expertise as much as funds, as demonstrated in the cases of Cambodia and Laos. The strong links between (in)equity and quality are widely recognized (Abadzi 2004; UNESCO 2004). Financially powerful donor and state discourses maintaining an economically instrumentalist focus on UPE statistics, over holistic EFA approaches to education systems, have contributed to the subordination of early childhood, adult literacy and, ultimately, educational quality.

I have shown how critical development theory frameworks can be useful for identifying political power dynamics driving policy processes. Conceiving of educational development activities from a theoretical perspective that challenges global structural inequalities may contribute toward substantively democratic policy and research approaches, and away from those geared to serve growth for a few to the detriment of quality in education. In this spirit, this research has reaffirmed the need for comparative educators to question and specify terms steering development, like "capacity," "ownership," and "partnership" within the context of globally disseminated agendas determining how they are understood. It has demonstrated, through CDA, some of the implications of language in processes of institutional policy transfer for globalized education initiatives. This research also contributes to the body of approaches in comparative and international education emphasizing the importance of understanding context, arguing that CDA provides an underutilized set of tools for doing so in an increasingly multiscalar policy environment.

This critical discourse analysis of EFA policies in Cambodia and Laos has revealed the concerns and voices of less financially powerful donor organizations and civil society as marginalized in policy content and formation. Civil society has made in-roads to policy participation for the promotion of holistic and rights-based EFA strategies in some contexts, emphasizing the neglected aspects of EFA that are important to quality improvement. However, engagement has been contingent on political power dynamics determining the discursive transfer of norms and material exchanges of resources between global, regional, and national spheres.

In terms of policy formation, this research has demonstrated how insti-

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tutionalized government collaboration and processes of critical engagement with wider civil society have been starting points toward national "ownership," conceived and maintained by those within the contexts hoping to be transformed. Local civil society groups and national coalitions have used EFA as a tool for leverage in advocacy for quality improvement. Examples include civil society shadow reports and policy contributions in Cambodia, contrasted with a lack of either of these in Laos. Both increases in research-based, locally gathered evidence from regional and national civil society coalitions (e.g., the Asia South Pacific Association for Basic and Adult Education and the NGO Education Partnership), and the production of alternative national education plans, are promising. These provide contributions to, and evidence of omission from, donor and government policy processes and texts. Continued support from global and regional bodies (such as those above, and the Global Campaign for Education) has been indispensable in materially supporting and promoting the legitimacy of such contributions. Concurrently indispensable is systematic prioritization of ownership transcending state mechanisms to incorporate subnational interpretations of what quality and, more fundamentally, education and progress mean. This involves conceptualizing capacity as the ability to articulate and identify needs, and addressing entrenched legacies of colonial and donor influence contributing to poorer education quality. My research has highlighted the lack of accessibility of documents and processes, especially in languages other than English. Although close examination has been beyond the scope of this study, one strong implication for policy and research is that CDA of interviews and informal documents in national and local languages could add to the relevance and understanding of these processes.

Another important dimension of prioritizing indigenous capacity to define (rather than manage imported) development(s) is the complicity of academia and comparative educators (a not exclusively Western, but global, elite) in the development project. Academics' pivotal roles in the forms education, donor, and NGO research collaboration can take are influential in promoting those beyond technical approaches, akin to Nederveen Pieterse's "emancipatory cosmopolitanism" (2006). Work in collaboration with education departments, research institutions, or NGOs, supporting and taking leads from those embedded in communities, can differ substantially from that of technical experts.

In addition to providing new insights and contributing to research on education policy making in Cambodia and Laos, the EFA policy documentation and processes discussed in this article share characteristics common (in terms of EFA initiatives rolled out globally by donors) with the other four countries included in the research (see n. 2 above), and beyond. Aid-receiving governments are sometimes identified as being more beholden to their funders than their citizens. Deconstructing how policy is produced, by whom, and

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under what historical and social circumstances provides evidence for those seeking to hold donors and governments accountable for commitments of equitable resource distribution and the right to relevant education(s) of good quality.

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Appendix

TABLE A1
EDUCATIONAL DEVELOPMENT POLICY ACTORS CONTACTED FOR INTERVIEW

Result of Interview Request	Interviewed	Unable to Schedule an Appointment	No Reply
Cambodia	AusAID (2) Mary Knoll Kampuchean Action for Primary Education (KAPE) (2) UNICEF University of Phnom Penh (2) CARE International Ministry of Education, Youth and Sports (MoEYS)	Individuals within the MoEYS Oxfam Australia	World Bank Asian Development Bank European Union Save the Children Individuals within the MoEYS World Vision
Laos	Lao People's Democratic Republic Ministry of Education (LPDRMoE) Plan International (3) Save the Children (2) UNICEF World Bank Asian Development Bank	AusAID World Education	Agence Francaise de Development (AFD) Individuals within the LPDRMoE The Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) Oxfam The Swedish International Development Agency (SIDA) UNESCO World Vision

NOTE.—Interviews were held at agency offices or in the Ministries and were with one representative, unless indicated otherwise in parentheses.

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TABLE A2
SAMPLES OF SEMISTRUCTURED INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

(How) is EFA a part of your agency's education program or projects here?
(How) are the education MDGs also referred to in policies and policy making?
How regularly does a representative from your organization attend education sector group meetings?
Which other organizations are members of the education sector groups?
Which donors, NGOs, and government regularly attend meetings?
Could you give some examples of your experience of the EFA Fast Track Initiative?

NOTE..—EFA = Education for All; MDG = Millennium Development Goal; NGO = nongovernmental organization.

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